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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

The high price of crop insurance

Taxpayers fork over billions, but only big farms and companies benefit

By Karina Atkins
Chicago Tribune

CASH CROPS, HIDDEN COSTS

Reporting for this story was supported by the MIT Environmental Solutions Journalism Fellowship.

For farmers who grow anything but soybeans and corn in Illinois, buying crop insurance is nearly impossible. Even an insurance agent couldn't figure out how to safeguard his vegetable and poultry farm against unpredictable weather and plain old bad luck.

Ed Dubrick, a first-generation farmer, worked at a local crop insurance agency for two years as he was starting up his small operation. He wanted the same federally subsidized safety net for his grapes, raspberries, asparagus and tomatoes that he was easily selling to

row crop farmers. But the bureaucracy was insurmountable.

"After probably two dozen phone calls and at least 100 hours put into trying to figure out what I needed to do, I decided crop insurance was too complicated for my diversified farm. It really felt like an instance of the blind leading the blind," said Dubrick, a veteran who

runs DuChick Ranch on 7 acres in Cissna Park, a small village 100 miles south of Chicago.

Crop insurance is intended to support "food security for American consumers and economic stability for rural America," according to the U.S. Department of Agriculture. But it doesn't cover all crops equally. It's primarily used by farmers growing the nation's four major commodities: corn, soybeans, wheat and cotton. And Illinois is the nation's No. 1 producer of soybeans and No. 2 producer of corn.

Only 10 insurance policies

Turn to Insurance, Page 4



Ed Dubrick uses a tractor to install posts for a fence around 5 acres on his land in downstate Cissna Park on May 2. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/TRIBUNE



ONE CENTURY, ONE ROAD

‘MAIN STREET OF AMERICA’ TURNS 100

Each mile of Route 66 promised freedom, escape, adventure and exploration, introducing countless Americans to their country

By Jonathan Bullington and E. Jason Wambsgans
Chicago Tribune

It was created to connect us, a fused chain of existing roadways — many unpaved — that stretched 2,448 miles across eight states and three time zones, starting steps from Lake Michigan in downtown Chicago and ending near the Pacific Ocean and Santa Monica's famed fishing pier.

Route 66, "The Main Street of America."

There is perhaps no better-known highway anywhere in the world. In its 100-year history, it has offered safe passage to Dust Bowl refugees, World War II transports and vacationing families. John Steinbeck called it "the mother road, the road of flight." Nat King Cole crooned about its kicks in a 1946 hit song. Disney and Pixar took inspiration from it for a 2006 blockbuster.

The famed highway conjured images of quirky roadside attractions, mom-and-pop diners, neon-signed motels and art deco service stations. Each mile promised freedom, escape, adventure, exploration. It introduced countless Americans to their country, to vast lands

Turn to Route 66, Page 12

Above: Roy's Motel & Cafe, seen Tuesday, is a motel, cafe and gas station that is being restored on Route 66 in the ghost town of Amboy, California. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Ethics legislation stalls in Springfield

Harmon tries 'brazen' maneuver that would help his election case

By Ray Long, Rick Pearson and Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

In the closing hours of the Illinois General Assembly's spring session, Senate President Don Harmon tried to pass legislation that would have wiped clean a potential multimillion-dollar fine against his political campaign committee for violating election finance laws he championed years ago.

Harmon's move came against the backdrop of the former Illinois House speaker's upcoming sentencing for corruption and abuse of power and almost instantly created a bipartisan legislative controversy that resulted in the bill never getting called for a vote.

The Oak Park Democrat's maneuver, characterized by critics as "brazen" and self-serving, also raises anew questions about how seriously political leaders are trying to improve ethical standards in a state government the electorate already holds in low regard.

Blowback to Harmon's action, particularly from inside the House Democratic caucus, was so severe it derailed an entire package of

Turn to Ethics, Page 6

TODAY'S WEATHER

High 80
Low 58



Complete Chicagoland forecast on Opinion, Page 12

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